and then realistically assessing the possibilities of its moving in the future from "a securitised hostile relationship to a normalised, if not friendly, one".

Bisaria's 20-month experience in Pakistan ending with his expulsion made him embark on this book with the aim of putting at its centre stage diplomats like himself who experience firsthand the occasional highs and the more frequent deep lows of this turbulent relationship. So, the book's principal protagonists are Bisaria's predecessors, some of whom also left detailed accounts of their own impressions and experiences of the relationship, frequently posing much the same questions that Bisaria grapples with. Not infrequently, the dilemmas and the situations encountered were also similar. Looking at the past through the distillate of his own experience enables Bisaria to make a somewhat depressing diplomatic history come alive.

BISARIA'S NARRATION OF THE CRISIS AFTER THE PULWAMA ATTACK MAKES FOR FASCINATING READING

This deep dive into India-Pakistan diplomacy combined with Bisaria's reflections on the present impasse also makes for an unusually thoughtful and timely work from a policy perspective. It undoubtedly merits a close and appreciative read by the specialist as well as the general reader. ■

good history books, this can therefore be read allegorically, in which case, certain 'lessons' are also evident. In Gokhale's account through the 1950s, India's leadership displayed strategic clarity and common sense in defining its national interests. Yet, this strategic vision was not always accompanied by the framing of sound and actionable policy objectives. Thus, recognising the People's Republic of China without first ensuring that potential trouble spots like the boundary issue were ironed out was a mistake. Gokhale also argues that diplomacy was often "driven less by systemic consultation than by individual preference". And finally, and most significantly, is the matter of prevalent mindsets. A pre-inclination to think as the British did was perhaps inevitable but this did make India more vulnerable to manipulation and deception. Similarly, India too readily assumed an alignment of interest between China and India and only gradually woke up to existing realities.

All history is vulnerable to the charge of retrospection, yet lessons such as these extracted from the archives of the 1950s make this a fascinating study to read, absorb and re-read. As Gokhale notes, "Hindsight might be a useful guide" to avoid repeating past errors. ■

—T.C.A. Raghavan

INDIA INTERNATIONAL

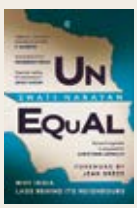
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